

Story1

The harsh wind whistled through the desolate mountains, biting at the man's exposed skin. He pulled his coat tighter around his shivering body and took solace in the rhythmic crunch of his boots against the frozen earth. The solitary man had grown accustomed to the isolation of this remote region, finding solace in the untouched beauty of the wilderness.

It was during one of his routine walks that the man stumbled upon a scene that shattered the tranquility he had come to cherish. The wreckage of a car lay twisted and broken, smoke rising from its crumpled hood. It was as if the world had collided with itself, an intersection of chaos and despair.

Resting precariously against the mangled metal, the lifeless body of a woman lay, her pale face framed by disheveled hair. The man's heart sank as he approached, his steady voice faltering in the face of an incomprehensible tragedy. He knelt by her side, overcome by a sudden impulse to stay, to be present in the final moments of a stranger's life.

As sirens wailed in the distance, announcing the arrival of emergency services, the man's voice found its footing. "There was a time, long ago," he began, his words carried away by the howling wind. "I knew a woman just like you."

He closed his eyes, conjuring memories from the depths of his soul. He spoke of nights spent dancing under star-filled skies, a love that bloomed like wildflowers in a hidden meadow. The woman's face served as a canvas for his tales, etching the stories of his past across her motionless features.

Time seemed to stand still as he spoke, the boundary between reality and memory blurring in the frigid air. The man shared stories of his travels, of mountains climbed and oceans crossed. He spoke of dreams pursued and dreams shattered, finding solace in the reminder that life was transient, that every experience, no matter how profound, eventually returned to dust.

As darkness began to descend upon the mountains, the emergency services arrived in a blaze of red and white. The wailing sirens shattered the stillness, bringing urgency and action to the scene. The paramedics rushed to assess the woman's condition, their voices overlapping with the man's solitary thoughts.

In that moment, the man realized the futility of his presence. He was an outsider to this woman's journey, an observer thrust into a narrative not his own. He stood up, dusting off the debris that clung to his coat, and took a step back from the chaos that now consumed the wrecked car.

He gazed at the silent mountains, their peaks towering above him in stoic solidarity. The tumultuous scene before him mirrored the ever-changing nature of existence itself. Like the mountains, he too had played witness to countless tragedies and triumphs, each a minor chapter in the grand tapestry of life.

In that moment of reflection, the man understood the fleeting nature of his connection to the woman. Their paths had intertwined briefly, a chance collision

in the tapestry of time. And now, as the paramedics tended to her lifeless body, he knew that his words had been more for himself than for her.

With a heavy heart, he turned away from the wreckage, knowing that life would resume its relentless forward march. He would continue his solitary walks, finding solace in the unyielding presence of the mountains and the untamed wilderness.

As the sound of sirens faded into the distance, the man carried the weight of the woman's story with him. He pondered the impermanence of events and life itself, finding solace in the ephemerality of his own existence. In the face of uncertainty, he embraced the wilderness that surrounded him, finding solace in its untamed beauty and profound stillness.

And so, the solitary man continued to walk, his footsteps echoing through the remote mountainous region. With each passing day, he became an integral part of the landscape, his own story merging with the ever-changing wilderness.

Weeks turned into months, and the man's walks took on a new purpose. The wilderness, once a solace, became a canvas for his creative impulse. He embraced the untamed beauty of his surroundings, capturing the essence of the mountains and the wilderness through paintings and photographs.

Each stroke of the brush or click of the camera shutter became a meditation, a way to honor the fleeting nature of existence. Through his art, he hoped to capture the essence of the woman he had encountered and the resilience of the human spirit.

As the man's work gained recognition, his paintings and photographs were exhibited in galleries and museums across the world. People were drawn to the raw emotion and authenticity captured in his pieces, a reflection of his encounter with the tragedy on that fateful day.

The man's art became a testament to the fragility of life and the power of human connection. His story, intertwined with the wilderness, became a beacon of hope and resilience for those who viewed his work. Through his expressions, he continued to breathe life into the memory of the woman, ensuring that she would never be forgotten.

Years passed, and the man's art became a legacy, a testament to the transformative power of tragedy and the connection between humanity and nature. His pieces were collected by renowned collectors and displayed in prestigious institutions, solidifying his place in the annals of art history.

But even with all the success, the man remained humble and rooted in the mountains he called home. He continued to walk, finding solace in the unchanging presence of the wilderness. Each step was a tribute to the woman he had encountered, a reminder of the fleeting nature of life and the importance of cherishing every moment.

And so, as the man walked through the remote mountainous region, his footsteps echoed not only his story, but also the stories of all those who have lived and loved amidst the ever-changing tapestry of existence.

One day, as he was wandering through the wilderness, he stumbled upon a remote cabin hidden deep within the mountains. Curiosity piqued, he approached the cabin and found it to be abandoned, covered in layers of dust and cobwebs. The windows were cracked, and the wood creaked ominously as the wind whispered through its worn structure.

Intrigued by the mysteries that lay within, the man decided to explore the cabin further. As he opened the creaky door, a rush of nostalgia and memories consumed him. The cabin was filled with remnants of a life once lived - old photographs, scrawled letters, and dusty journal entries.

With trembling hands, the man picked up a faded photograph. It depicted a couple standing in front of the very cabin he was now in, their arms wrapped around each other in embraces of love and unity. The man recognized the woman immediately - it was the woman he had encountered all those years ago at the car wreck.

As he delved deeper into the abandoned cabin, he discovered journals filled with the woman's hauntingly beautiful words - poems, stories, and reflections on life's enigmatic nature. The pages were filled with raw emotion and longing, a testament to the woman's creative soul.

The man felt an inexplicable connection to the woman's spirit, as if she had left a piece of herself within these walls. He decided to honor her memory by transcribing her words onto canvas, each stroke of his brush capturing the essence of her poetic musings.

With every painting he created, the woman's spirit seemed to shine through, breathless and profound. Her words resonated within him, guiding his hand across the canvas, creating masterpieces that spoke of love, loss, and the unruly beauty of human existence.

Word of the man's extraordinary art spread far and wide, attracting curious art enthusiasts and critics to his secluded cabin. They were captivated by the ethereal quality of his work, the way he managed to capture the very essence of the woman and her profound thoughts.

The abandoned cabin transformed into a sanctuary of creativity and inspiration, a pilgrimage site for those seeking the connection between art, life, and nature. The man and the woman became legends, their stories intertwining in a tapestry of beauty and melancholy.

The man continued to paint, driven by an unyielding desire to reveal the invisible threads that connect humanity to the natural world. His artwork spoke of forgotten dreams, lost love, and the eternal quest for meaning.

Years passed, and the man's masterpieces were displayed in prestigious galleries, hailed as timeless expressions of the human experience. People were drawn to the emotional resonance that emanated from each painting as if the woman's spirit was still alive, whispering secrets to those who beheld them.

Yet, amidst the acclaim and adoration, the man never forgot the woman who had unknowingly jump-started his artistic journey. He always carried her memory within him, a constant reminder of the fragile beauty of life and the importance of acknowledging fleeting moments of connection.

As he grew older, the man retreated back into the mountains, seeking solace and inspiration in the untouched wilderness. He would sit on a rocky ledge, overlooking vast valleys and cascading waterfalls, and let the whispers of nature fill his soul.

And in those tranquil moments, the wind would carry faint echoes of the woman's voice, a gentle reminder that he had fulfilled his purpose - to keep her memory alive through the power of art.

As he closed his eyes one final time, the man smiled, knowing that he had left behind a profound legacy. His art would continue to inspire, teach, and touch the hearts of those who beheld it, for the stories he had shared would forever remain etched in the collective consciousness of humanity.

-----The End-----

Story2

Over the many years since he had last seen them, the mountains had seemingly grown taller. Or perhaps, Finch observed to himself, it was he who had become smaller. He meant this in both a physical and metaphorical sense: the former, because he was now in his late fifties and stooped, so as to not put so much pressure on his incurved spine; the latter, because his once-vibrant mind, long caught in the relentless rhythms of a tedious life, had lost some of the primitive capacity to appraise the world and its wonders.

Finch owned and, until recently, operated a mortuary deep in the heart of Appalachia. The mortuary had been passed on to him by his maternal lineage, which consisted of weavers—a fact of which Finch was somewhat proud, despite it not accurately reflecting his own contemporary role. He employed a staff of licensed professionals capable of embalming and washing the corpses, and as a result, he spent his days either socializing with mourners or wandering in the mountains, through the numerous roads and paths that crisscrossed it like a tapestry bordering on disintegration at its seams.

The days had grown shorter, as September ebbed away, and a chill seeped into every crevice of the land. Although it deterred some from venturing into the Appalachians, Finch was not dissuaded. He followed a dirt road that led into a remote segment of the Appalachian Trail, winding along the shoulder of a seldom-traveled mountain range. The engine of his breath and the rhythmic

sound of his boots on the brown, loamy soil were the first noises to break the serene silence of the morning.

As he reached a bend in the road, his journey was suddenly halted by the tragic sight of a swerving 1950s coupe. The car had flown off the road into the underbrush, making a disastrous impact with such velocity that it wrapped around a tree. A mangled, contorted wreck the color of black cherries. The driver, a young woman wearing a skirt and pantyhose but no shoes, had been thrown clear of the brutal accident. She lay about twenty feet away from the wreckage, on her back, one ankle tucked under the opposite shin, her arms above her head as if in a casual, balletic pose. Her hair, a tangle of dried alfalfa, had come loose from its updo, partially obscuring her downturned eyes. It was possible she had been in such a state for days or even weeks.

In a whisper that barely penetrated the seclusion of the wilderness, Finch uttered, "So unsimulated is this place." He walked over to the lifeless woman, examining her condition from a better, up-close perspective. He crouched down, took the woman's wrist between his fingers, and prayed for some furious reaction. But he felt nothing, no spasm under the skin. The wrist was cold and waxy, with the appearance of a raw parsnip plucked a few days before.

Stricken with grief and the horror of such calamity, Finch picked up the woman's limp hand and held it, his eyes welling with tears. He wondered why, in this particularly uncaring part of the Earth, it was inevitable that some should perish so suddenly, forgotten.

Heaving a deep sigh, he glanced at his surroundings. A dense fog was settling on the mountains, and Finch knew he ought to summon assistance before the ghosts of the wilderness could completely lay claim to the woman's shattered body. The nearest town was eight miles away; he doubted he would get there and back before sundown.

For a brief moment, Finch hesitated to leave her side, as, oddly enough, they were each other's only company amidst their lonely surroundings. But swinging between hope and despair at the notion of not finding help, he felt a strong sense of urgency.

With a heavy heart and a newfound determination, Finch hurried away in the direction of the nearby town. The sun had risen, cascading an orange glow upon the land, giving the region around him the appearance of a sepia-toned photograph. The frost of the cold morning retreated into the earth or hung in the air as thin clouds of water vapor. Finch marveled at the day as he retraced the route he had taken earlier. Unusual for such deep and desolate country, which was subject to intense thunderstorms and sudden arctic winds, causing the earth to dry out and crumble.

"What a deuce of a land it must be, this land I am in!" Finch muttered to himself, suddenly filled with an overwhelming sense of awe at the wild, untamed terrain. "Exists for some in prosperous fairness, and for some in cruel calamity."

Finch's path took him along a winding train track, intersecting his trail like a storybook villain. Below, the land sloped steeply away, leading down to a greenswept valley, glistening with morning dew. A river coursed through the bottom, fed by the spring thaw and summer rains and various mountain lakes, whose still shores no foot had disturbed.

One such lake stood nearby, its shores and silent bed haunted by Finch's own childhood memories. A memory of fishing with his father, and exploring the woods with a sense of adventure and youth that seemed to dissipate with time. As he walked by, the wind blew an ominous gale in his face, causing him to pull his tartan scarf tighter around his neck as he hurried on, rattled by the bad omen that seemed to linger in the air.

At last, a beaten-down truck stopped beside him, with two uniformed men in its bed. "Sir, we got word of an accident down the mountain," the driver spoke, a concerned look etched on his face. "Would you like a ride?"

The relief on his face was evident, and as he slumped back into the truck bed, Finch leaned onto his knees, observing the landscape as they ventured back through the wilderness. His mind, like the wind, swirled with chaotic thoughts of grief and disbelief.

When they finally returned to the accident scene, the sun had fallen considerably, casting lengthened shadows that left an eerie unreality over the disturbed surroundings. Amidst the gathering gloom, Finch pointed the men in the direction of the woman's body, smeared with congealed blood upon her leg.

One of the men—a stout fellow with red hair that resembled burnt underbrush—hailed the body up and carried it onto the stretcher they had brought with them. The woman appeared considerably less human now and more like an effigy as she lay on the dimly lit makeshift bed.

"In the solemnity of our days, we cloud upon each other," mused Finch. "One hurrah to another."

Once her body was safely loaded onto the back of the truck, the men took final accounts of the wrecked car, lamenting its crushed state as if it was a prized possession. Then, they clambered into the vehicle one by one, leaving Finch to himself. In the meantime, Finch offered his condolences to the woman. Affected by her unceremonious passing, he made a silent promise to ensure she received a proper and dignified burial.

In the vast, unbroken silence that immediately followed their departure, the world seemed to transform and reform, leaving only the mountains, the haunted lake, the creased dirt road ahead, and the wreckage of a crashed car that would soon grow dim with ghostly presence.

In this desolate landscape, Finch found solace in the company of the mountains, whispering a transcendent symphony of fleeting past, the impermanence of events, and the undeniable continuation of life itself. Finch looked off into

the wilderness, a new sense of purpose filling him as he thought, "In wilderness, illogic is pursued, and logic is denied, but life moves on." And with that realization, he began his journey back into the peculiar, untamed world he called home, with an appreciation for the fleeting nature of life and a newfound determination to not take it for granted.

-----The End-----

Story3

The old dirt road snaked through the dense forest, the peaks of the Catskill mountains jutting up around it. John hiked at a steady pace, his boots crunching on the gravel. It had been decades since he last visited these parts, where his family had a cabin when he was a child. He remembered spending long summer months splashing in the creek, the scent of pine needles warm in the sun.

A sharp bend in the road revealed a ghastly scene—a sedan had smashed into a rocky outcrop, the front end crumpled like an accordion. His heart seized up for a moment as a flood of memories assaulted his senses. He recalled learning to drive on these winding roads, clutching the steering wheel with sweaty palms as his father grasped the passenger handle with white knuckles, warning him to slow down. As adrenaline coursed through his veins, He rushed over quickly but saw immediately that the female driver was motionless, clearly deceased, her pallid face marred with rivulets of dried blood. The woman must have misjudged the turn, realizing her mistake seconds too late.

Rushing over to investigate further, he saw a woman slumped over the steering wheel, airbag deployed but lifeless, clearly deceased. He whipped out his cellphone but there was no signal. Holding back panic, he checked for a pulse multiple times, to no avail. Her pale face was marred with rivulets of dried blood, her limp body twisted in a way that signaled her neck was likely broken.. "Ma'am? Can you hear me? His voice echoed against the vastness of the mountains, desperate but in vain. No response came. He checked her neck again for any signs of life but felt only cold, clammy skin.

The accident must have just happened, for the engine was still ticking, motes of steam rising from the dented hood. John kept trying 911 to no avail, dread blooming in his chest like a poisonous flower as each call went unanswered. As minutes passed, the futility sunk in like a stone. He was alone here with this lifeless stranger, in the middle of nowhere, stranded without a signal. What if he was unable to get help? The thought sent his mind reeling. Flashes of being stranded for days with this poor woman assaulted his imagination.

His mind drifted to his late wife, Alice, who had passed away just six months ago after a long battle with Alzheimer's. The memories of losing her were agonizingly raw, each recollection opening the wound anew. He sat down on a large boulder on the side of the road and put his head in his hands, sobbing uncontrollably as visions of Alice's slow deterioration and eventual passing flooded his mind. The tears flowed freely now, a torrent of angst and regret and longing for the tender

moments they had shared over the years. He cursed himself for delaying this trip to their old cabin, realizing this could be the last time he visited these cherished mountains.

With the daylight hours waning, John decided to search the vehicle for clues as to the driver's identity. In the glove compartment he found insurance papers which listed her name as Jenny Thompson. His heart clenched at the sight. This was no stranger, this was someone's daughter, perhaps someone's mother. The thought made his stomach churn. How would her loved ones react to such a brutal loss? His grief felt raw yet again, amplified by these recurring thoughts.

Darkness descended upon the dense forest, a chill enveloping everything under the shadows of night. John took off his jacket and placed it gently over Jenny Thompson's body, a small act of compassion for this poor soul. He spotted a wedding band on her left hand, glinting in the pale moonlight. His heart broke yet again, envisioning a husband and children waiting desperately for her to return, only to have their lives shattered by this grim discovery.

The hours passed slowly as gnarled branches of towering pines became shrouded in night. The moon rose high in the inky sky, casting an eerie glow over the crash site. His attempts to call 911 remained futile, each unanswered ring ratcheting his anxiety higher. An unearthly silence set in, broken only by the occasional hoot of an owl and the chirping of crickets beginning their nightly chorus. John sat in the dirt, leaning against the boulder, drifting in and out of a fitful sleep. Exhaustion overtook him briefly but his discomfort with the grim scene nearby made rest nearly impossible. His mind wandered again to Alice in her last days. He had sat by her bedside for hours, clutching her hand, filled with a tumult of emotions. Loss, regret, and longing for just one more lucid day together. The helplessness of being unable to stop life from slipping through his fingers. He looked over at Jenny Thompson in the passenger seat and was overcome with the same mix of emotions all over again. Another life cut short, another light extinguished into the void. The darkness seemed poised to swallow them whole.

The woman's cell phone rang in the glove compartment, startling in the darkness, a surreal sound amid this placid scene of death. He answered to hear a man's frantic voice. "Hello? Honey, where are you? I've been calling for hours." John struggled to find words to convey the grim news. "There's been an accident," he said gently. As the man cried out in anguish, the tears John had struggled to contain now streamed down his face. He told the man as gently as he could about finding his wife's lifeless body amid the wreckage. The man's sobs echoed through the phone. The man pleaded for help, desperation clearly evident in his broken voice as he tried to absorb the devastating news. John spoke in hushed tones, trying to comfort him from afar, relaying details of how he had found Jenny amid the crash site wreckage. How she appeared at peace, if only in stillness. The man kept repeating her name, as if he could will her back through the phone line. His anguished sobs tore at John's heart; the raw pain in his voice was almost too much to bear. But he stayed on the line, keeping

vigil with this stranger who was now locked in a grief as fathomless as the inky night sky above.

The purr of an engine shook him from his reverie. Headlights appeared around the bend, a park ranger's pickup truck. Doors slammed, voices called out. As the ranger examined the crash, shaking his head grimly, John walked back down the road to meet him, filled with relief and sorrow commingled. The ranger radioed for emergency responders while John explained the events of the long night.

The mountains stood as they always had, indifferent to human dramas, reminding him of the fleeting nature of all things under heaven. John returned home late that night, his mind churning over the day's traumatic events. He thought of that poor woman, Jenny, and her loved ones who would soon get the terrible news. The fragility of life had been driven home once again. He climbed into bed, yearning for Alice's warm body next to his, but found only the blank expanse of mattress. His last thought before drifting off was of the mountains, aged sentinels watching in silence through the dark. They had witnessed untold scenes like this one, and would continue to do so, long after all human life had passed into dust.

-----The End-----

Story4

At first, it was no more than a sensation. As he walked along the road, the evening shadows seemed to contain some premonition. It was a remote place with no houses, no farms, only the sharp outline of the mountains against the sunset, full of danger and beauty. There was no sound apart from the birds and the general hum of insects, maybe a dog barking in the valley—all the components of emptiness. As he continued walking, he caught a flash of light reflected on a metal surface, then he stopped and saw an overturned vehicle in the ravine below.

It was as though the landscape were in shock. He could see fresh signs of damage—the tire marks at the edge of the gravel road, where the car must have gone over, and the scrapes where the undercarriage dragged across a rock, leaving behind a screech in the trees. The wheels of the car were pointing upward, as if the world had been turned on its head and the car were now going to continue driving across the sky.

Some metres away, there was a woman lying face down on the ground. She must have got out through the window of the car and tried to crawl back up the escarpment to the road. She lay motionless, clinging to the upright world with a mobile phone in her hand.

He called out to her, but there was no response.

He phoned the hotel in the small town where he was staying and asked the desk clerk to send the emergency services. He explained roughly where he was, but

his directions were vague—out in the mountains, he had come through a beech forest, he could hear the sound of a motorbike.

It took him a while to get down to the site of the crash. Her eyes were open, but she was no longer breathing. There were no signs of injury, no marks on her body as far as he could see. Her elbows and knees were dusty with soil. One of her sneakers had come off.

There were no other occupants in the car. The radio was on, the real world still keeping in touch. He turned the car off but then decided to leave the tail lights on, so the rescue services would find them more easily if it got dark. The interior of the car smelled of coffee. There was a paper cup on the ceiling, the contents all over the dashboard.

He took the phone from her hand. She must have tried to speed-dial for help, he thought, but had instead managed to switch on the flashlight. He redialled the most recent number. A man named Alex, whose face came up in a small bubble. He got no answer and left a message, telling Alex there had been an accident. He placed the phone back into her hand and stood over her, letting her know that the emergency services would soon be there. Here they come, he said to her. Maybe he was trying to reassure himself. Below, in the valley, a siren could be heard at that point, but it seemed to be going further away, to some other accident elsewhere.

There was nothing to do but wait. He sat down beside her and watched the sunlight disappearing behind the mountains. Everything was calm now. Nothing more could happen. It took him a while to notice that the birds had stopped singing. The insects began to attack and he got one of the broken branches to keep them away.

He wanted to know where she was from and what had brought her to Transylvania. Was she a tourist? And who was this man Alex? Why was he not returning her calls?

She was unable to answer his questions, so he began to tell her something about himself, to pass the time. As though it were up to him to keep the conversation going while she lay there saying nothing. He told her that he had once spent a year teaching in Bucharest, and he had now come back to see some of the places where he had been. After the fall of the Communist regime, there was an old cinema in Bucharest where he used to go and watch John Ford movies in English. It was a funny place, he said, because there was a man out of sight in the projection room translating the dialogue into Romanian. It was like a running commentary, delivered in a flat, disinterested tone, as if the translator had seen this movie a million times, there was nothing new in it for him. And sometimes, he told her, the voice disappeared, leaving the audience guessing. Maybe the invisible translator got distracted, lighting a cigarette or eating a sandwich, or maybe he was so taken by the action in the movie that he was suddenly unable to speak. Then the voice would come back and rush through long scenes in a few breathless lines.

That cinema is gone now, he told her.

What made him think she would be interested in hearing all this? He was telling her anything that came to mind, to fill the silence. There was a restaurant he used to go to that had bear meat and wild boar on the menu, but he found out it was all pork, with thick gravy. During the Communist era, it was forbidden to write about food because there was so little available. A novel needed the approval of seven different censorship departments before it could be published, often with large sections deleted.

The silence grew exponentially whenever he stopped talking.

He said that the rescue services seemed to be taking their time. Maybe his directions were at fault. He phoned the hotel once more and they assured him that an ambulance was on the way. These narrow mountain roads were built in a time before cars were invented, when it was all horses and people travelling on foot. And maybe the urgency was gone now that she was dead. He told her not to worry, he would stay with her until they arrived, even though it was almost fully dark by then, only the stars out above them and a black infinity in the trees.

He assumed that she was German. This man Alex, is he your partner, your husband, maybe? Had she, like him, come here alone, driving through the mountains, returning to a place she had been to before and wanted to keep in her memory?

He thought of her body being taken to Bucharest and relatives coming to claim her. Alex would be there. Would Alex want to speak to him, the last person to spend time in her company on the mountain? Would he want to be brought to the site where she had died?

He wondered how long it would take for a place like this to grow back. The recovery team was bound to do far more damage when removing the car from the site. He told her about the German film director who had gone back to the location where he had made a movie about a ship being dragged over a mountain. When he returned, years later, the jungle had completely grown back: there wasn't even a wooden post left behind as a physical memory. The place had returned to its original state. Primal. Nothing had lasted, apart from the movie itself. The place where he now sat waiting with her would also recover. The scars in the earth would be washed away by autumn rains. The rocks dislodged by the vehicle on its descent would settle back into the soil. The trees would stand upright again. The earth will forget, the way we sometimes forget what's happened to us.

He sat for a while without talking, as if it were her turn to speak. Then he heard some movement in the trees. It felt to him like a substantial presence, maybe a bear. He had heard that these mountains were heavily populated by brown bears, and it was illegal to hunt them. In that moment, he felt alone. Abandoned. He had been left behind in the living world, while she lay

beside him, beyond danger. He had a duty to stay alive, to feel hope and to be interested in the future, while she had come to some peace with herself. Nothing could hurt her now.

He stood up and started waving the stick. He shouted. He gave out a deep masculine growl. Then he sat down again and held her hand. He could think of nothing else but to sing a song, something to keep her safe, one that he had learned from his mother as a boy. At the top of his voice, he sang a German folk song to scare off the predators.

-----The End-----